

Pending Decisions and Open Questions

Kashmir bus route rationalisation → *Transport Policy* manuscript

Assembled 2026-10-01 · repository revision **b1367fc**

Every question in this document needs a human on this project to answer it. None of them can be settled by reading the code, re-running a module or searching the literature — where a question *could* be settled that way it already has been, and the answer is recorded in Part F rather than asked here. Every analysis module has run; nothing below waits on computation.

Read Part A first. It ranks all open items. Items 1-9 block submission; items 1-4 are the ones to start this week. Parts B-E give each item's question, evidence, options and recommendation.

Checked against the journal. The *Transport Policy* Guide for Authors was read on 2026-10-01: 8,000-word norm, 250-word abstract, double-anonymised review, and a mandatory declaration of generative-AI use.

Companion files. Each editorial flag appears in place in `Kashmir_Manuscript_Working_Draft.pdf`. The superseded v1 of this document is in `paper/archive/`.

Pending Decisions — v2

Kashmir bus route rationalisation → Transport Policy

Rewritten 2026-10-01 against the live repository and the journal's own *Guide for Authors*. It replaces v1 (kept in paper/archive/ with its full original discussion). Everything here is still open unless it is in Part F.

Why a v2

v1 grew by appending updates, so its early pages described finished work as unfinished. While rewriting it, the journal guide was checked for the first time, and it changed three things:

- 1 **The length limit is 8,000 words, not 10,000.** "Articles should normally be no longer than 8000 words." The 10,000 in our planning came from the co-author brief and was never verified.
- 2 **Review is double-anonymised.** The manuscript file must not identify the authors — including our GitHub links, which carry a personal username.
- 3 **Use of generative AI must be declared** in a section before the references, and the authors must have reviewed and edited all AI-assisted text so it reflects their own work.

Part A — The list, ranked

#	Decision	Who	Effort	Blocks
1	D4 GPS consent, anonymisation, ethics status	Prashant	a conversation	submission
2	D13 authors, order, affiliations, corresponding author, CRediT	Prashant + all	an email	submission
3	D26 cut to 8,000 words — what moves to supplementary material	all	2–3 days	submission
4	D28 declare AI use; every author reviews the AI-assisted sections	all	1–2 days reading	submission
5	D27 anonymise the manuscript for double-blind review	Prashant	2 hours	submission
6	D2 the August field-observation table: real, with sheets?	whoever ran it	a message	\$6, Abstract
7	D5 run the §2.1 literature protocol, or drop it	Sharvesh, Ankit	2 days or 2 hours	\$2, Figure 2
8	D3 "Srinagar Municipal Area" wording in co-author text	Policy-Failure author	1 sentence	\$1, \$3, \$7
9	D1 §1.6 says six sections; there are eight	Misti, Avny	1 paragraph (drafted)	\$1
10	D20 accept four corrections to how §4 described the engine	Prashant	read §4	\$4
11	D22 report V2 (operator benchmark) as a fail	Prashant	yes/no	\$6
12	D7 report the fleet as 1,011 plus the 1,130–1,266 observed-pace range	Prashant	yes/no	Abstract, \$5, \$8
13	D21 per-lakh benchmark: 63.5 on network-served residents (above MoHUA 40–60)	Prashant	yes/no	\$4, \$5, RTO deck
14	D25 confirm cost & emission constants, or keep \$5.12 marked provisional	Prashant	an hour	\$5.12
15	D29 the public repositories: personal data, operator data, DOI	Prashant	an hour	data statement
16	D30 co-author editorial flags (citations, unsourced numbers, missing paragraph)	co-authors	1–2 days	\$1, \$2, \$3, \$7
17	D18, D24, D12, D11, D10 — confirm the current handling	Prashant	read §5	—

If you only do four things this week: 1, 2, 3 and 4. Nothing else blocks submission as hard.

Part B — Blockers

D4 · GPS consent, anonymisation and ethics (1)

Question. On what basis were the driver GPS traces collected; were drivers told they might be used for research or planning; what is released; and was any ethics body consulted?

Why it matters. It can stop the paper at the editor's desk. ~157 drivers' daily movement is human-subject data by any reading, and validation channel V4 — the paper's strongest observational evidence — rests on it. The §3.6 ethics paragraph is deliberately blank.

What is already true. Only aggregates are used or released (corridor speeds, dwell, counts). The one per-driver table is published only de-identified in the citable repository. The collection window is **February-June 2026** (D23, resolved).

What only you can write down: (i) the collection basis (app terms? were drivers told?); (ii) the anonymisation — already "aggregates only"; (iii) ethics status: approved (committee + reference), exempt, or **not consulted**. *"Not consulted" is an acceptable answer to write down. Silence is not.*

Also: rotate the Firestore service-account key that was on disk in the trace repository.

Recommendation. Aggregates only + a plain statement of (i)-(iii). **If nothing is done:** cannot submit.

D13 · Authors, order, affiliations, CRediT (2)

A draft CRediT table is in `paper/front_matter/credit_statement.md`; surnames, order, affiliations and the corresponding author are blank and cannot be inferred. Per the guide, author details go **only on a separate title page** (D27). **If nothing is done:** cannot submit.

D26 · Cutting to 8,000 words (3 — new)

Question. The draft has ~13,600 body words against an 8,000 norm. What moves out?

Why it matters. A 70 %-over manuscript is a likely desk return. The journal's "normally" gives a little room, not 5,600 words of it. (The 8,000 appears to apply to the main text; the guide does not say whether references and tables count — assume they do not, but keep well under.)

Proposed allocation (details in `paper/WORD_BUDGET_PLAN.md`):

	Now	Target	How
§1 Introduction	2,343	900	Policy-Failure block → §3.3, condensed; merge §1.1–§1.2
§2 Literature	1,413	900	narrative focus; move protocol detail to supplement (or drop, D5)
§3 Study area	1,242	700	diagnostics → §4.2 or supplement
§4 Methodology	2,422	1,700	equations stay; QA gates, faithfulness detail → supplement
§5 Results	2,412	1,800	§5.10 transfers, §5.11 operations, §5.12 cost → supplement (one sentence each stays)
§6 Validation	1,041	650	V4 detail → supplement
§7 Discussion	2,045	1,000	merge co-author block into §7.2; trim §7.8
§8 Conclusions	475	350	—
Total (Abstract excluded; it is 228 of a 250 limit)	13,393	8,000	

Nothing is lost: a *Supplementary Material* file carries the moved subsections, and every number stays in the repository and the ledger.

Options. A — this allocation (recommended). B — target a journal with a longer limit (D17 below; check its guide first). C — submit long and ask the editor (risky).

If nothing is done: the manuscript goes in at ~13,600 words.

D28 · Declaring generative-AI use (4 — new)

Question. The journal requires a section "*Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process*" before the references, and holds authors accountable for reviewing and editing every AI-assisted passage and checking every AI-supplied reference.

The facts to declare. Claude (Anthropic) was used to write and run the analysis code, draft §4–§6, §8, the Abstract and parts of §7, compile the ledger and bibliography (each reference was checked against Crossref), and draw the figures. AI must not be listed as an author (git commit trailers are not authorship).

What the authors must actually do. Read §4–§6 and §8 critically and rewrite them in their own voice where needed — this is also the best way to cut words (D26). Draft statement:

During the preparation of this work the authors used Claude (Anthropic) to write and execute analysis code, draft and edit sections of the manuscript, and verify references. After using this tool, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the published article.

If nothing is done: a policy breach discovered after submission is far worse than a declaration made before it.

D27 · Double-anonymised review (5 — new)

Two files are required: a **title page** (authors, affiliations, acknowledgements, competing interests, corresponding author) and an **anonymised manuscript** (no names, affiliations or acknowledgements). Three things in our draft identify the authors:

- 1 Links to [github.com/Princu-Babu/...](https://github.com/Princu-Babu/) and [GrotesqueChip/...](https://github.com/GrotesqueChip/) — replace with an anonymised mirror for review (e.g. anonymous.4open.science) and restore the real links on acceptance.
- 2 The competing-interest option that says the authors built the engine and app — this goes on the title page, not in the manuscript.
- 3 Self-references such as "our dashboard" or "we developed Bus Sathi" — rephrase in the third person.

If nothing is done: likely returned for anonymisation.

D2 · The August field-observation table (6)

A co-author draft contains ten on-street sessions (1–12 August) on named Srinagar corridors. If real, it is the paper's **only demand-side observation** — the single biggest possible upgrade to §6. No data file, method note or claim ID exists, so **no number from it is used**. Needed: who, when, where, method (fixed-point count? how long?), the raw sheets (a photo is enough), then ledger IDs.

Recommendation: ask this week. **If nothing is done:** it stays out; §6 remains supply-side only.

D5 · The §2.1 systematic-review protocol (7)

§2.1 describes a search that has **not been run** (placeholders [Scopus], [N]). Option A: run it (~2 days) and code Table 1. Option B: delete §2.1 and Table 1 and keep §2 narrative (~2 hours; also helps D26). Fake PRISMA counts are misconduct; a narrative review is not. **Recommendation:** B unless someone has two days. **If nothing is done:** placeholders cannot go to the journal.

D3 · "Srinagar Municipal Area" wording (8)

Three co-author passages (Policy-Failure block, the §3.1 heading — already changed and disclosed in FLAG 3-A — and the §7 Policy-Contribution block) describe a Srinagar-only study; the plan covers ten districts. **Recommendation:** one joining sentence by that block's author: "*The institutional analysis*

is specific to Srinagar, where permit overlap is most acute; the network plan covers all ten districts of Kashmir Division."

D1 · §1.6 roadmap (9)

§1.6 says "Section 6 concludes"; the paper has eight sections. Replacement text is drafted in FLAG 1.6-a. One paragraph.

Part C — Sign-offs (a yes or no each)

#	Decision	What the draft does now	Recommendation
D20	Four places §4 misdescribed the engine: κ is 0.33 not 0.18; Eq. 8 <i>does</i> set 67 rural headways; the merge rule adds a 2.5 km start condition and merges only into a cluster's leading trunk; layover is $\times 1.10$ and the backbone fleet is $\max(\text{formula}, \text{CHALO})$	§4 corrected, each with CL-59	Accept — a reviewer with the public code would find them
D22	V2: plan backbone fleet is $1.29\text{--}1.58 \times \text{CHALO}$ scaled to 15 min	reported as fail , circularity disclosed first	Accept — the band was pre-registered
D7	Fleet: 1,011 as specified; 989–1,058 under parameter uncertainty; 1,130–1,266 at observed pace	Abstract, §5.7, §6, §8 say so	Accept ; if the RTO needs one number, 1,182 (median at observed pace)
D21	Buses per lakh: 15.4 (division), 43.6 (engine's Euclidean served), 63.5 (network-served, above MoHUA 40–60)	all three reported	Accept ; check which one the RTO deck quotes
D25	Cost/CO ₂ constants (km/L, INR/km, grid factor, e-bus kWh/km) are unverified ranges	§5.12 labelled provisional; not in Abstract	Confirm with sources, or move §5.12 to supplement (helps D26)
D18	20 of the 55 routes the plan calls high-priority fall in the objective bottom tier	reported in §5.8 with a policy sentence	Keep; the RTO should justify or demote those 20
D24	Day-one ~8 boardings/trip on the backbone vs 19–37 today	§5.11 frames the plan as a supply-led bet; recommends staged procurement	Keep
D12	13,087 residents lose bus access; 32 via-routings suppressed	named in §5.9 and Table 5g	Keep as prominent as it is
D11	Before/after equity Gini not computable (merged permits have no geometry)	stated, not faked	Keep
D10	$\tau = 100 \text{ m}$, $\theta = 0.65$	both swept; direction of the τ result invariant; 207 surviving pairs pass the engine's own merge test at $\theta = 0.65$	Keep. Upgrade available : τ can now be anchored empirically from the Microsoft footprints (distance from building to nearest walkway) — ~1 hour of work if wanted
D17	Journal	<i>Transport Policy</i> (8,000 words, double-blind, AI declaration)	Confirm. If you consider another journal, check its guide first — do not assume its limits

Part D — Public repositories (D29)

Item	State	Needed
Citable repository Princu-Babu/Bus-sathi	live, tagged v1.0.0, CI green	Get a DOI: link the repo in Zenodo, then create a GitHub Release from tag v1.0.0. Cite the DOI in the data statement.
Data statement (front_matter/data_availability.md)	points at the working repos	Point it at Bus-sathi (anonymised mirror for review, D27)
driver_days.csv (per-driver, hashed IDs)	public in bus-sathi-paper and its history ; only de-identified in Bus-sathi	Decide: remove from bus-sathi-paper history (needs a force-push; teammates re-clone), or accept
CHALO / SSCL aggregates	published in all repos	Confirm SSCL/Chalo are content; if not, withdraw and keep only derived outputs
Permit register	published	Confirm the RTO is content with release
Your email in two engine geocoding scripts (Nominatim contact)	public	Accept, or swap for a project address
CITATION.cff authors	Prashant + "Bus Sathi research team"	Replace after D13

Part E — Co-author editorial flags (D30)

Open flags in the manuscript, grouped by owner. Each is a tinted callout in the working-draft PDF.

Misti, Avny (§1)

- 1.1-a — five external figures need page-level citations (490→763 M urban projection; 0.13–0.14 buses/1,000; MoHUA 0.44 benchmark; ">400 Class-I cities"; "<15 agencies publish GTFS").
- 1.1-b — citation style, and "CSE & CITIES Forum" appears two ways. **Pucher et al. is 2005, not 2007.**
- 1.2-b — the US\$ 40 M/km metro and US\$ 2.5 M/km BRT figures need a year and currency base.
- 1.3-a — the frequency-rule equation was lost in extraction; the authors must supply it.
- 1.4-b — "64.5 % female ridership" and "2.5 million tourists" have no source.
- 1.5-b — objective O5 promises validation §6 cannot give; align to "decision-robustness".
- 1.5-c — contribution (3) claims a "seasonal" demand proxy; seasonality is not modelled. Narrow the claim.
- PF-a/3-B — move the Policy-Failure block to §3.3 (also D26).

Sharvesh, Ankit (§2)

- 2-B — the Euclidean-vs-network critique is **not novel**: cite Gutiérrez & García-Palomares (2008) and Biba et al. (2010) by name before §4 measures it.
- 2-C — the data-intensity cross-tabulation depends on D5.
- 2-D — reconcile every citation with references.bib (map in COAUTHOR_CITATION_MAP.md).

Krishna (§3)

- 3-C — Table 2 lists data the study does not hold (land use, terrain, tourist arrivals, fleet register, cost norms): obtain or strike.
- 3-A — heading change disclosed; revert if you object.

Ankit, Avny, Misti (§7)

- 7-A — the **political-feasibility paragraph is missing**: 458 merged permit rows are contested livelihoods; cite the international network-redesign literature. Required.
- 7-C — "applies to 400+ cities" must read as preconditions met, not validity shown.
- 7-E — the Policy-Contribution block overlaps §7.1–§7.2 and uses Srinagar scope (D3).

Prashant (§3.6)

- 3-E — the reproducibility wording can now be strengthened: every module runs end to end and CI reproduces the results in the citable repository.

Part F — Resolved (for the record)

#	Resolution	Date
D6	Data-maturity ladder ranked by Sobol' indices (§7.5)	2026-09-30
D9	Microsoft footprints downloaded; V1 passes (p 0.975 route, 0.950 grid), partly circular	2026-10-01
D14	Figures 1, 3-9, 9b, S1, S2 drawn by fig_generate_all.py; Figure 2 waits on D5	2026-09-30
D15	Superseded by D26 (the limit is 8,000)	2026-10-01
D19	a03 aligned with a04's Jenks convention	2026-09-30
D23	GPS window is February-June 2026; DATA_AVAILABILITY.md corrected	2026-10-01
7-B	= D6	2026-09-30
7-D	Funding sequence: 30 % of the fleet reaches 92 % of coverage (§7.7)	2026-09-30

Full v1 discussion of every item: paper/archive/PENDING_DECISIONS_v1_2026-09-30.md.